

Passage 1:

Shopping Metaphors

Shopping is an activity that people do all over the world. Sometimes we go shopping to buy things we need. In many countries, shopping is also an activity that people do for fun. People often enjoy going to the store, looking at products, choosing something, putting it in the shopping cart, and spending money to buy it. Because people enjoy shopping, e-commerce platforms have tried to make the experience of visiting a website like the experience of shopping at a physical store. One way e-commerce recreates the experience of shopping is by using **metaphors**. Here are some common metaphors that make online shopping feel like shopping in a store.

The Shopping Cart

One of the most common metaphors is the “shopping cart” or “shopping basket.” In a physical store, customers place products into a cart or basket. E-commerce sites copy this process by allowing customers to add products to a virtual cart. Users feel like they have moved the product to a cart, but in reality, no physical object has moved. Using the metaphor of a shopping cart creates a sense of ownership, so that customers are more likely to buy an item if they add it to the “cart”.

The Storefront

Another metaphor is the “storefront.” Real shops have a front entrance with windows and a door. Stores display products in the windows, and when the customer enters the store, they usually see the newest or most popular products first, along with products that are on sale. The homepages of online stores resemble this storefront. Instead of displays in windows, the homepage shows pictures and descriptions of featured products. Promotional banners at the top of the page often show discount offers.

Window Shopping

Some people like to look at the products at stores, even though they don’t plan on buying anything. We call this “window shopping” because people like to look at the displays of products through the windows. People often enjoy window shopping online too. They go to the website, look at pictures and videos of products, and read the descriptions. Sometimes people add products to their shopping carts, or save them to buy later.

Store Layout

Large department stores, shopping centers, and malls, are divided into smaller areas or stores. The layout of e-commerce websites are organized in a similar way. From the homepage, users can click on categories of products, such as “Men’s Clothing,” “Electronics,” or “furniture”. Going to the different pages for these categories feels like walking around the store or mall and going to different departments.

Checkout

The checkout process also mirrors physical shopping experiences. With physical shopping, customers go to a cashier to pay for their items. Online stores recreate this experience through digital checkout pages where users review purchases, enter payment details, and confirm orders. Many sites use terms like “checkout,” “billing,” and “receipt” to make it feel like a physical store.

The products

Perhaps the biggest limitation of online shopping is that the customer cannot touch the products. In a physical store, customers can see example products on display, try on clothes, and look at products before buying to make sure they are not damaged. To make up for this limitation, online stores use visual design like high-quality images of products, zoom functions, and 360-degree views. Some online clothing stores even use virtual dressing rooms or augmented reality so users can “try on” items digitally.

Metaphors like these play an important role in the success of e-commerce. They bridge the gap between physical and digital retail by making online environments feel familiar, trustworthy, and easy to navigate. With these metaphors, e-commerce platforms recreate many aspects of traditional shopping while adding the convenience and efficiency of digital technology.